

Conflict in the Holy Land

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

24 June 2021

To an individual Bahá'í

Dear Bahá'í Friend,

The Universal House of Justice has received your email letter of 12 May 2021 inquiring about its perspective on the conflict in the Holy Land. We have been asked to share the following with you.

The concerns that have prompted you to write are warmly acknowledged. Indeed, the heart of a Bahá'í cannot but be distressed when contemplating the suffering of so many people in the world who are caught up in human conflicts. The friends must remember, however, that the conflicts, injustices, and suffering they observe are symptoms of the disintegration of the old world order. Ultimately, political affairs must be reordered and the lesser peace established, for humanity is a single entity and the best interests of any part are inextricably bound up with the best interests of the whole. Yet, so long as particular nations, peoples, and political factions pursue their own interests—whether by political, economic, or military means and often at the expense of others—the great challenges facing humanity will remain insoluble. While each side portrays its position in terms of what is just and right, using whatever means available—especially the media and global forums—to gain public favor, Bahá'ís must be careful not to be drawn into such arguments, for they are the well-wishers of all peoples and nations. “Let them refrain from associating themselves, whether by word or by deed, with the political pursuits of their respective nations, with the policies of their governments and the schemes and programs of parties and factions”, Shoghi Effendi stated. “In such controversies they should assign no blame, take no side, further no design, and identify themselves with no system prejudicial to the best interests of that world-wide Fellowship which it is their aim to guard and foster.”

In general, the tendency to take sides and fight about issues is at the heart of the intractable problems afflicting humanity at this time. Therefore, to wade into such disputes by taking one side or another ultimately exacerbates, rather than resolves, the problem; the challenge, instead, is to find a way to rise above the specific conflict and unite people in the search for just and lasting solutions.

The Palestinian issue is a political one and should be solved at the political level. Bahá'ís have no advice to give and do not believe that political declarations by them will resolve the fundamental issues involved. The attitude of the Bahá'í community is succinctly stated by Shoghi Effendi in a letter dated 14 July 1947 to the chairman of the United Nations Special Committee on Palestine, which may be found on pages 287–288 of Amatu'l-Bahá Rúhíyyih Khánum's *The Priceless Pearl* (London: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1969, 2017 printing). This position, quoted below, is in keeping with the general principle of non-involvement in politics.

The Bahá'í Faith is entirely non-political and we neither take sides in the present tragic dispute going on over the future of the Holy Land and its peoples nor have we any statement to make or advice to give as to what the nature of the political future of this country should be. Our aim is the establishment of universal peace in this world and our desire to see justice prevail in every domain of human society, including the domain of politics.

It is hoped that the foregoing comments will be helpful to you in your consideration of this matter. May your endeavors in the path of service to the Cause and to humanity be blessed and confirmed.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]